

THE CHECKLIST

THE HIDDEN COSTS OF BUILDING A SAUNA

Every cost DIY sauna budgets miss, named before you buy a single board. With a budget worksheet.

THE SAUNA HOST

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WHY SAUNA BUDGETS DOUBLE

Most DIY sauna budgets cover the wood and the heater, then run into everything else. One builder who shared his numbers on Reddit budgeted $4,000 and finished at $9,000. The overrun came from items like a $2,000 electrical panel upgrade, $800 of circuit work and $400 of vapor barrier and vents.

None of those costs are surprising once you know to look for them. This checklist names them before you buy anything.

How to use it: walk through each section before you commit to a design. Tick an item once you've confirmed whether you need it, then write the quote or estimate in the worksheet at the end. Anything you can't price yet is a question for your electrician, builder or HOA.

THE CHECKLIST

1. ELECTRICAL (WHERE MOST BUDGETS BREAK)

- [ ] **Panel capacity check.** A traditional heater needs a dedicated 240V circuit, usually 30–50A. Many homes built before 1990 have 60A or 100A panels, and upgrades are reported at $2,000–4,000.
- [ ] **Dedicated circuit and wire run.** Price the full distance from your panel to the sauna. An outdoor sauna at the back of the yard can need trenching and conduit.
- [ ] **Licensed electrician.** Budget for one from the start. Heater wiring is not a DIY step.
- [ ] **Electrical permit and inspection.** Nearly always required for a new 240V circuit.
- [ ] **Controller and any required disconnect.** Check your heater's manual and local code for exactly what's needed.
- [ ] **Heat-rated lighting.** Standard fixtures aren't rated for sauna temperatures.

2. SITE AND FOUNDATION

- [ ] **Level pad or piers.** Concrete piers or a raised pad keep the wood framing off the ground.
- [ ] **Drainage.** Water has to move away from the base, not pool under it.
- [ ] **Access and delivery.** Measure every gate, door and turn between the street and the build spot. Kits and long boards don't bend.
- [ ] **Shade and placement.** Afternoon sun can push exterior walls well above 130°F. Siting is cheaper than fixing it later.
- [ ] **Clearing.** Tree, root or old-slab removal.

3. WALLS, ROOF AND WEATHERPROOFING

- [ ] **Foil vapor barrier and foil tape.** Skipping it lets moisture into the walls, and mold repairs can run past $5,000.
- [ ] **Insulation.** For walls and ceiling.
- [ ] **Vents.** An intake and an exhaust in the right places, plus a fan if your layout needs one.
- [ ] **Sauna door.** Tempered glass or a solid door, opening outward.
- [ ] **Roof.** Metal roofing reflects heat and lasts. Include underlayment and flashing.
- [ ] **Exterior siding and rain screen.** For outdoor builds.
- [ ] **Corrosion-resistant fasteners.** Stainless or hot-dipped, inside and out.
- [ ] **Termite protection.** A year-round concern in warm climates.

4. HEATER AND STONES

- [ ] **The heater**, sized to your room's volume and any glass. Undersizing is one of the most common first-build mistakes.
- [ ] **Sauna stones.** Often sold separately from the heater.
- [ ] **Heater guard** and any clearance materials your heater's manual requires.
- [ ] **Thermometer and hygrometer.**

5. INTERIOR

- [ ] **Wall and ceiling paneling.** Sauna-grade tongue-and-groove wood.
- [ ] **Benches and backrests.** Clear, knot-free wood with hidden fasteners, so nothing hot touches skin.
- [ ] **Flooring.** Tile, sealed concrete or duckboards. Not carpet, laminate or vinyl: one builder's laminate warped within three weeks.
- [ ] **Floor drain**, if water will be used.

6. PERMITS, HOA AND INSURANCE

- [ ] **Building permit.** Ask your city or county whether a sauna counts as an accessory structure.
- [ ] **HOA approval.** Common in planned communities. Get it in writing before you buy materials.
- [ ] **Flood-zone rules.** Some zones require minimum elevation.
- [ ] **Homeowner's insurance.** Tell your insurer about a new heated structure.

7. TOOLS, LABOR AND THE EXTRAS

- [ ] **Tool purchase or rental.** Saws, nailers, ladders.
- [ ] **Help.** Paid labor or a friend's weekends.
- [ ] **Waste removal.** Offcuts, packaging, old materials.

- [ ] **Bucket, ladle, hooks and towels.**
- [ ] **A cool-down.** An outdoor shower, hose or cold plunge for between rounds.
- [ ] **Contingency.** Add 20% to the total. Seller guides report installation running 30–50% over the equipment price.

8. ONGOING COSTS

- [ ] **Electricity.** Heater kW × hours of use × your rate per kWh. A 6 kW heater running a full hour at $0.15 per kWh costs about $0.90 at most. Heaters cycle, so real use is usually lower.
- [ ] **Exterior finish.** Plan on re-oiling or re-staining every 1–2 years outdoors.
- [ ] **Stones and parts.** Stones break down over time and need replacing.
- [ ] **Termite inspections**, for outdoor builds in warm climates.

YOUR BUDGET WORKSHEET

Fill in an estimate for each line now, replace it with real quotes as they arrive, and add up both columns before you commit.

CATEGORY	MY ESTIMATE ($)	QUOTED ($)	ACTUAL ($)
Electrical			
Site and foundation			
Walls, roof and weatherproofing			
Heater and stones			
Interior			
Permits, HOA and insurance			
Tools, labor and extras			
Contingency (20%)			
Total			

BUILDING IN FLORIDA OR THE GULF COAST?

Heat and humidity change the build. Moisture gets trapped in walls, termites never take a season off, and 85°F air won't cool you between rounds. **The Hot-Climate Sauna Guide** covers how to build, place and care for a sauna where it's warm and humid, from the team behind a sauna and cold plunge studio in Tampa Bay. Find it at **thesaunahost.com/hot-climate-guide**.

BEFORE YOU BUILD

This checklist is for planning, not professional advice. Electrical work on a 240V circuit must be done by a licensed electrician, and permit, code and HOA rules vary by location. Check yours before you start.

WHERE THESE NUMBERS COME FROM

- Sauna Buying Regrets: What Reddit Learned the Hard Way, sauna.guide (budget overrun, panel upgrades, flooring, vapor barrier)
- Building a Sauna in the Southeast, tahoesaunacompany.com (exterior heat, termites, refinishing)
- Florida Outdoor Sauna Buying Guide, sweatdecks.com (installation overruns)